



S.E. THURSTON FIRE AUTHORITY



sethurstonfire.org • 360-458-2799

SUMMER 2026



A Message from Fire Chief Mark King

Summer is here, bringing more opportunities to connect as a community. We truly appreciate the support you give to Southeast Thurston Fire Authority as we work to protect lives and property.

The latest news is that our bond proposal will be on the August 4 primary ballot. If approved, it would fund renovations at four stations—Yelm, Rainier, Lake Lawrence, and McIntosh—and replace three fire engines that are reaching the end of their service life.

Over the past two years, we've taken a thoughtful and transparent approach to these projects. We developed a Capital Facilities Plan to identify our most urgent needs, then engaged with the community about those priorities and potential funding options. These projects go beyond our daily operating budget, so a bond is the practical way forward.

Renovating four existing stations costs less than building a new one and helps improve service across all areas we serve. Many of these buildings haven't had major updates in more than 30 years, and improvements are needed to better protect both the public and our firefighters.

For example, two stations can't be staffed due to inadequate space and living quarters. Renovations would allow us to staff them in the future, improving response times and coverage across the district.

We're also prioritizing firefighter health, with planned upgrades like improved exhaust removal systems and decontamination areas to reduce exposure to harmful substances. Firefighter cancer and other occupational illnesses remain a serious concern in the fire service.

If approved, the bond would cost about \$0.20 per \$1,000 of assessed value—around \$8.33 per month for a \$500,000 home. For more information, visit sethurstonfire.org/bond or contact me at 360-458-2799 or info@sethurstonfire.org.

Water Safety Tips as Summer Begins



As warmer weather brings more people to lakes, rivers, and swimming areas, we are seeing an increase in water rescue calls. A few simple precautions can help keep everyone safe.

Wear a life jacket. Even strong swimmers can struggle in cold or moving water.

Watch children closely. Always keep kids within arm's reach near water.

Know the conditions. Rivers and lakes can have strong currents, changing depths, and cold water temperatures.

Avoid alcohol while swimming or boating. It slows reaction time and increases risk.

Bring a phone and tell someone your plans before heading out.

Taking a few simple safety steps can help ensure everyone enjoys the water safely this summer.

Planned Improvements at Four Fire Stations

If approved by voters this August, the proposed bond would renovate four existing fire stations to address safety, space, and operational needs that have developed over decades of use.

Station 21 in Yelm, which handles about 70 percent of the district's emergency calls, is already at capacity. Renovations would add sleeping quarters, offices, and workspace to support emergency response.

At Station 24 in Rainier, firefighters currently stay in a manufactured home across the parking lot from the apparatus bays. The project would add sleeping quarters inside the station and create training space to improve response efficiency.

Station 22 in the Lake Lawrence area is too small for modern fire engines and lacks important safety systems such as diesel exhaust removal and decontamination areas. Renovations would expand the facility and add living quarters to support future staffing.

Station 25 in the McIntosh area, originally built in the 1960s and now used primarily for storage, would be updated to better support service in a growing residential area.

Together, the projects would modernize key facilities, improve firefighter safety, and support emergency response across the district.



S.E. Thurston Fire Authority
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Wildfire Season: Residents Should Prepare Now

Wildland fires are becoming more common in our region. Southeast Thurston Fire Authority responded to 31 wildland fires in 2022 and 58 in 2025—an increase of nearly 90 percent in three years.

Each year before wildfire season, SETFA firefighters complete specialized training to prepare for these incidents. Twenty-seven personnel maintain "red card" certification, qualifying them for wildland firefighting locally and across the region.

But preparation isn't just for firefighters. Residents can also take steps now to help protect their homes and families.

One of the most important is creating defensible space. Maintaining a "green zone" of about 30 feet around your home by clearing dry vegetation and reducing combustible materials can slow the spread of fire and improve a home's chances of survival.

Lieutenant Kelly Corey says firefighters often see dry grass, brush, or yard debris along driveways or against homes—conditions that can quickly carry flames to structures and

hinder emergency access. Trimming vegetation, removing dead plants, cleaning roofs and gutters, and storing firewood away from the house can significantly reduce wildfire risk.

Every household should also have an evacuation plan. Wildfires can move quickly and cut off escape routes, so residents should understand evacuation levels: Get Ready, Get Set, Go Now.

Plans should include pets and livestock and identify emergency contacts.

Residents are also encouraged to sign up for Thurston County emergency alerts (see QR code) to receive evacuation notices and other updates during emergencies.



After many wildfires, firefighters see homes like this spared while surrounding vegetation burned. Properties with defensible space are far more likely to withstand approaching wildfire, says Lt. Kelly Corey.

